

Purpose

The policy defines and sets expectations regarding persons visiting hospitalized patients. It provides guidance for visitors to decrease transmission of communicable diseases from visitors to patients & vice versa. It applies to all inpatients across the hospital.

Scope

All healthcare staff and employees are responsible for the enforcement of this policy. In addition, security staff and patient's service staff are responsible to implement this policy especially at critical area level and when visitors are coming outside visiting hours.

Visiting Hours:

Visitors are encouraged to visit during the hospital visitation hours which are as follows:

	Morning Time	Evening time
During working days (from Sunday to Thursday)	–	From 3 pm to 6 pm
During weekend & Public holidays	10am -12pm	3 pm to 6 pm
Ramadhan timing		
During working days (from Sunday to Thursday)	–	8 pm to 10 pm
During weekend & Public holidays	10 am to 12 pm	8 pm to 10 pm

Visiting Critical care area:

Due to the critical nature of certain units (i.e., intensive care units, High Dependencies) visiting hours are more restricted.

	Morning Time	Evening time
During working days (from Sunday to Thursday)	-	From 5 pm to 6 pm
During weekend & Public holidays	9am -10 am	5 pm to 6 pm
Ramadhan timing		
During working days (from Sunday to Thursday)	9 am -10 am	5 pm to 6 pm
During weekend & Public holidays	9 am -10 am	5 pm to 6 pm

NB: From 11 am to 12 pm there is consultation visiting hour, only one person can enquire about the patient's condition preferably next of kin.

Visitors are advised to visit their patient one by one and one person at a time. Visitor must not provide care for their patients unless stated by Healthcare providers. It is advisable that only mother and father can visit their child in these areas.

Visiting outside visiting hours:

Visitors that will be visiting outside of regular visiting hours should contact patient service staff who will liaise with ward nurses and doctors of the concerned ward to confirm the need to visit to discuss the case or attend counselling.

General Rules:

- Smoking is forbidden inside the hospital
- Visits by children under the age of 12 years are not allowed

- Refrain from loud conversations or from any behaviour that may be disruptive to a patient
- Follow hand hygiene advice below
- It's best not to sit on the patient's bed as this can spread germs. Use the chairs provided.
- Don't touch the patient's wounds or any medical equipment they are attached to, such as drips or catheters. This can cause infections.
- Don't share property, such as toiletries, tissues or items of hospital equipment with the patients
- Perishable food should not be brought in by visitors for patient consumption
- Outside linen or blankets are not allowed inside the hospital.
- Flowers should not be brought into certain hospital wards such as critical areas (AICU, PICU, NICU & high dependencies) and Oncology wards.
- Visitors in non-visiting time need a visiting pass which can be collected from PRO.

Hand hygiene

When visiting someone in hospital, always clean your hands using soap and water or alcohol hand rubs. Do this when you enter or leave a patient's room or other areas of the hospital. If you are concerned about the hand hygiene of doctors, nurses or anyone else who comes into contact with the patient you are visiting, you are encouraged to ask them whether they have cleaned their hands.

Illness

Visitors will be asked NOT to come to the hospital if they have

- Vomiting and/or diarrhoea and until they have been symptom free for 48 hours
- Coughs, colds or flu-like symptoms
- Any infectious condition e.g. chickenpox, mumps etc.

Visiting patients in isolation room/Cohort area:

All visitors must practice hand hygiene before and after visiting their patients

If visitors are helping or providing help to the patients they are requested to wear full PPE

Visitors planning to visit multiple patients must visit isolated patients last in the list.

References

Title of book/ journal/ articles/ Website	Author	Year of publication	Page
Northern Health & Social care trust Visiting Policy UK	Catherine Hinton	2008	1-16
<i>Greater Baltimore Medical Centre Visitors Policy</i>	Director of Security	2013	1-4

Review / Revision History

Revision History			
Revision	Description of change	Revised by	Revision Date
1	Initial Release	Zaina AL Maskari	2018
2	Second release	Dr. Amal Al Tai	2020
3	Third release	Dr.Amal Tai	2022
4	Reviewed	Ibtisam Al Amri	2024
5			
Written by		Checked by	Authorized by
Zaina AL Maskari		Dr. Amal Al Tai	Dr. Amal Al Tai